

Open, Except for the Open Parts

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The word used to mean something specific enough to build a movement on: source available for inspection, license permitting modification, a build process anyone could reproduce from published steps. None of that was ever generous. It was just precise, which is why it was useful.

Watch what happens to the word once it becomes valuable to a party that has no intention of doing the thing it originally named. First it comes to mean the weights are downloadable, even though the data that produced them and the training process that shaped them remain undisclosed, which is a little like calling a recipe open because you may examine the finished cake. Then it comes to mean an API is available to the public, with the weights themselves withheld, which drops inspection and reproducibility both and keeps only "a customer relationship exists." Eventually it comes to mean a waitlist, a request form, a proprietary server that will process your query if you agree to the terms, at which point the only thing "open" still denotes is that the front door has a doorbell.

Each step is defensible in isolation, which is exactly how semantic dilution survives scrutiny that a single large redefinition would not. Nobody stands up and announces that open no longer means open; the word simply gets used, repeatedly and confidently, in contexts one notch further from its original referent than the last time, until the distance traveled is only visible if someone lines up the definitions side by side, which almost nobody does, because doing so requires noticing that a change occurred rather than a technology having advanced. The word is not being redefined by argument. It is being redefined by inertia, kept in circulation because the reputational credit it carries, transparency, community, the opposite of a walled garden, transfers to whoever says it regardless of whether the referent came along for the ride. The parts of "open" that were expensive, the inspectable data, the reproducible pipeline, the license that permits a competitor to actually compete, are the parts that quietly stopped being included. The parts that were cheap, a landing page and a sign-in flow, are the parts still called open, loudly, on the grounds that something about the system remains accessible to someone, which was never the bar the word was coined to clear.